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Abū Naṣr al-Fārābī (c. 870–950), known as the ‘Second Master’ after Aristotle, was one of the leading Muslim philosophers of the Islamic Golden Age. The influence of his writings lasted for centuries, up until the early modern period, and covered almost every area of philosophy, including religion, metaphysics, political philosophy and more.

In *The Book of Religion*, he defines religion as a set of beliefs and actions, bound by specific rules, established for a community by its first ruler to achieve a certain purpose. In Islam, the first ruler is the Prophet Muhammad, who shapes the community’s beliefs and practices through divine revelation. This means, if the ruler is truly virtuous, whatever he advises his aim will be “ultimate happiness,” which can only be fully achieved in the next life. Therefore, a virtuous religion teaches correct beliefs about God, the universe, the soul, and prescribes the right way to worship and act towards other beings.

Philosophy, on the contrary, aims for true knowledge; understanding things as they really are through demonstrative reasoning. For al-Fārābī, prophets and revelation form a bridge between philosophy and religion, presenting philosophical truths and explaining them in a way understood by everyone.

Since most people cannot grasp complex philosophical proofs, religion uses persuasive forms to ensure they understand and live by right beliefs and actions, enabling them to be capable of entering heaven. For al-Fārābī, true philosophy and virtuous religion can never conflict because they are two different paths used for reaching the same truth.